myself in a new pecking order. And at the same time I was trying to abolish the pecking order altogether. Brutality crept in, and so did injustice and prejudice: at times I was a font of transgression, and that was a difficult thing to be in rural Australia back then. In one of my schools, I was dragged up to the Principal's office on an unknown charge and was beaten with a cane for some mysterious 'indiscretion'. It later transpired that there had been a theft and my peers had pinned it on me.

I was drawn to books. Books and magnets. My grand-father remembers me coming to summer school with a bag of books, one of them a giant biography of Albert Einstein. That could've got me hated, I suppose, but if you're not in the habit of thinking like that, you never will. There was just this lovely confluence, for me, between the physical world and the life of the mind, and I dived into both at that age. And you could say it has coloured everything I've done since then. Everything. My sense of computers and my sense of justice and my view of authority. It was all there during this period in Goolmangar and I felt the force of my own personality coming out.

I had these ethical adventures in my childhood and they made me bigger. One time there was an anti-war rally and my parents had commissioned themselves to create a piece of live street theatre especially for it. Mum made a Styrofoam M16 rifle, painted black with a shoulder strap. My stepfather was dressed in fatigues from the army surplus place, and we went to the butcher and ordered two pints of blood. I remember the strange looks we got. We drenched my stepfather in the blood and later that day he got arrested because of the fake gun. Later, my mother helped this guy who was engaged in guerrilla scientific studies of the nuclear test site at Maralinga in the Australian desert, where, with the agreement of the Australians, the British had conducted both 'major' and 'minor' tests of nuclear weapons between 1952 and 1963. The 'minor' tests, in which nuclear bombs were set alight, or blown up in amongst conventional explosives, or placed on aeroplanes that were deliberately crashed, were actually far worse than had been publically acknowledged, scattering radiation over a wide area. The British and the Australian governments, however, denied that there had been, or was, any danger to servicemen or to the Aboriginals that lived in the area. This turned out to be a lie, although they would only admit it years later. So this friend of my mother was searching for the truth, and I remember, one night, we had just come from there and were driving along a